

What we could have been
written by
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INT. ALEX'S OFFICE, SINGAPORE CULTURE MEDIA BUILDING -
EVENING

ALEX adjusts her glasses as she sorts through a pile of paperwork on her desk. Her eyes are red-rimmed, dark circles beneath them. Her bangs are haphazardly clipped to the side, a few strands brushing her cheek.

She types at her computer. ASSISTANT NINA knocks on the glass door. Alex waves her in without looking up.

ALEX

Hi Nina, tell my boss to give me
some extra time to finish this
article...

NINA

Good luck with all that, but
that's not why I'm here. There's
someone who wants to meet you.

ALEX

Listen, if it's that Russian
SoundCloud rapper who made a song
about the Merlion, tell him to
come back next year. I'm way too
booked right now.

NINA

Actually, it's someone named
Jasmine. You wrote an article
about her bar?

Alex's hands stop mid-type. A beat. She shoves all her paperwork into a drawer and quickly tidies her desk.

ALEX

Ok ok, let her in. Uh... clear my
schedule for the next hour or so.

Nina nods and leaves. Alex exhales slowly, bracing herself.

Another knock. She looks up.

JASMINE stands in the doorway – a young Indian woman in her mid-twenties, short wavy hair, sharp arched eyebrows. She wears a long red skirt with intricate white borders paired with a loose green tank top. Silver-gold jewellery catches the light at her neck and wrists – an easy,

assured mix of Indian and western style.

ALEX (CONT'D)

Come in.

Jasmine enters without a word, her brows slightly furrowed. She settles into the chair with the quiet confidence of someone who has earned the right to take up space. She holds Alex's gaze steadily – long enough to make Alex look away first.

Jasmine reaches into her brown messenger bag and pulls out a copy of the Singapore Culture Paper. She sets it on the desk. An article is circled: *"Jazzclues Renewed: Jasmine Bringing Ethnic Jazz Fusions into the Jazz Scene."*

JASMINE

So is this your way of getting my attention?

ALEX

I...

FLASHBACK – PRIMARY SCHOOL

ALEX (7) sits behind JASMINE (7) in class. A pile of chocolates sits on Jasmine's desk. Jasmine holds one up and turns to Alex with an amused look.

JASMINE

You're the one putting these chocolates there secretly, right? You want my attention, is it?

ALEX

Mm...

FLASHBACK ENDS – BACK TO ALEX'S OFFICE

JASMINE

Alex...

ALEX

(deflectively)

I just did what was right. This is a culture paper.

JASMINE

Doing what's right, huh...

ALEX

Listen, I—

Alex cuts herself off. She sits back, steadying herself.

JASMINE

Very nice of you, doing the right thing and all. Hm. A bit hypocritical, though. All these years you never thought of making things right with me — not after whatever happened in high school.

Alex looks up. There's something in Jasmine's expression — restrained anger, old hurt. Alex opens her mouth, then doesn't.

JASMINE (CONT'D)

And yet... and yet, here you are. Writing a whole article on a jazz bar that half the public doesn't even care about. And somehow you convinced them — I had so many people walk through my door just last night. I almost want to take your hand and tell you I'm grateful.

Alex's hands knot together on the desk. Her gaze drops — not quite shame, but close to it. She can't hold Jasmine's look.

JASMINE (CONT'D)

But I can't, Alex. Not if this is your way of asking for some kind of forgiveness. Or worse — if you just did it for some greater good or something. You tell me ah, how am I supposed to feel?

Jasmine stands and slams her palms against the desk.

But Alex has already drifted.

FLASHBACK — HIGH SCHOOL, SUNSET

ALEX (14) is being dragged outside by JASMINE (14). The golden light cuts long shadows across the school grounds.

JASMINE

I'm giving you a chance to explain yourself, Alex.

ALEX

Jas...

JASMINE

WHY DID YOU NOT SHOW UP FOR OUR PERFORMANCE? YOU KNOW WE WERE SUPPOSED TO PLAY TOGETHER, RIGHT? YOU KNOW THAT WAS MY LAST PERFORMANCE IN THIS SCHOOL, RIGHT?

ALEX

I... was sick.

JASMINE

Oh, now you want to lie to me, is it? I went to your mum and asked what happened. She said you went to the library to study. What sick person goes to the library to study, huh? You think I'm stupid?

Alex doesn't answer. She takes in her surroundings – the dimming sky, the near-empty school yard, the distant chatter filtering in from the gates. The sounds blur. She begins to dissociate, a high ringing filling her ears, until Jasmine grabs her shoulder.

JASMINE (CONT'D)

Are you listening to me?

FLASHBACK ENDS.

JASMINE (CONT'D)

Are you listening, Alex?

Alex snaps back. Jasmine lets out a slow sigh and lowers herself back into the chair.

Nina knocks and enters with two glasses of water, placing them on the desk. She glances at Alex. Alex gives a small shake of her head. Nina sets the tray down.

NINA

By the way, our boss asked to meet you soon. Shall I schedule it after this hour?

ALEX

Oh... yeah. Thank you, Nina.

Nina leaves. Jasmine takes a long sip of water.

ALEX (CONT'D)

I—

JASMINE

Do I get my answers today?

Alex's jaw tightens. Jasmine runs her fingers through her bangs, exhaling hard. She covers her face with her palm.

JASMINE (CONT'D)

You really didn't need to clear your very busy schedule for me then.

ALEX

Yes... but I wanted to.

Jasmine looks up. Their eyes hold — less charged than before.

JASMINE

Are you sure about that? This whole time I've been running my mouth, trying to make sense of something that happened ages ago. I thought you'd have asked me to shut up by now.

ALEX

(a beat, then quietly)

I'd like for you... to shut up now.

Jasmine stares at her. A flash of surprise — then something warmer. Alex's face goes red.

ALEX (CONT'D)

Sorry — no, I meant—

JASMINE

The floor is yours.
Jasmine crosses her arms and settles back into her chair.
Alex exhales and straightens.

ALEX
Jas, I really want to clear
things up. I always... wanted to.
But I held back. Every time.

JASMINE
I know, Alex.
Alex clasps her hands on the desk.

ALEX
Can I monologue for a minute?
Jasmine blinks. A beat. Then a slow nod and a faint smile.

ALEX (CONT'D)
I was hoping to see you,
actually. Somewhere deep down I
knew that if I wrote this piece,
you'd probably storm down to my
office. You haven't really
changed much from back then. But
that's what I always li-
She stops herself.

ALEX (CONT'D)
—admired about you.
Jasmine tilts her head, caught somewhere between confusion
and recognition.

ALEX (CONT'D)
You always took charge. Whether
it was organising performances
for the school jazz club or
running to the teacher when you
thought she'd marked me wrong.
But I was different. I was kind
of a... coward. I still sort of
am. And that's what caused the
drift between us.

(MORE)

ALEX (CONT'D)

And I want to... I really want to
apologise for it. Back then, I
actually...

FLASHBACK – ALEX'S BEDROOM, 15 YEARS AGO

ALEX (14) lies flat on her bed, one arm draped over her
eyes. A calendar hangs on the wall above her, one date
circled in blue marker with the words: "*our last*
performance." A knock at the door.

ALEX'S MUM

Ay, got no school today? I
thought you were performing with
Jasmine?

ALEX

I, uh, have to study. Important
test coming up. Sorry, Mum.

ALEX'S MUM

Eh? I didn't know... okay, I see.
Let me know if you need anything.

Alex doesn't reply. She pulls the blanket over her head
and cries for a long time.

After a while, she gets up, grabs her bag, and heads to
the front door.

ALEX

Going to the library to study,
Mum. I'll be back...

ALEX'S MUM

Oh okay, come home before five!

Alex leaves.

MONTAGE – EXT. SINGAPORE STREETS, DAY

Alex boards a bus. Her face is blank, distant.

She transfers to the MRT. Same expression, guilt now
visible underneath it.

Another bus. She stands among the packed passengers, her
stillness conspicuous. The guilt has settled in.

She gets off and sits at a bus stop. A puddle of rainwater
on the ground – her reflection stares back at her.

EXT. JASMINE'S HDB BLOCK – AFTERNOON

Alex stands outside Jasmine's front door. Aloe vera and money plants line the corridor outside. She raises her hand to knock.

She doesn't.

Instead, she pulls out a scrap of paper from her bag, writes "*I'm sorry*" in small letters, and slides it under the doormat. She leaves quickly.

EXT. NATIONAL LIBRARY – NOON

Alex sits at a table, staring at open books. She can't focus. She flips through her notebook and finds a doodle – a guitar and a pipa, side by side. Beneath it: "*Jasalex jazz debut!*"

She closes the notebook fast.

EXT. ALEX'S HDB BLOCK – EVENING

Alex is almost home when she sees Jasmine standing outside her door, guitar slung on her back, hair windswept. Jasmine is talking to Alex's mum.

Alex ducks behind a pillar. She watches. She doesn't move. When it's safe, she slips around the back and takes another route home.

INT. ALEX'S BEDROOM – LATER

Alex lies on the floor, staring at the ceiling.

ALEX'S MUM

(outside the door)

Alex, want some snacks I got?

ALEX

No, Mum. I'm not very hungry today.

She doesn't move. Tears run sideways down her temples.

FLASHBACK ENDS.

ALEX (CONT'D)

I just... I wish I could fix what I did back then. It was really stupid. But I'm sorry, Jas. I really, really am.

When Alex opens her eyes, Jasmine is no longer across the desk. She's standing beside her – shoulder resting lightly against the cabinet. Her expression is warm and a little

proud.

JASMINE

You know, it's nice seeing you
talk so much.

Alex goes red.

ALEX

I'm just clarifying...

JASMINE

Mhm, mhm.

The room feels different now. Jasmine turns to the window.
The sun is setting. In the trees outside, two birds sit
side by side on a branch, calling to each other.

JASMINE (CONT'D)

Nice sunset view from here.

ALEX

Yeah... Is it still your
favourite part of the day?

JASMINE

Hell yeah! But it's not complete
without a hot cup of chai and
some rice crackers!

A laugh escapes her. Alex smiles back.

Jasmine returns to the chair and reaches into her bag. She
produces a business card and her phone, setting both on
the desk.

JASMINE (CONT'D)

Here.

ALEX

Ah?

JASMINE

My card – to make this meeting
look somewhat official in case
your boss gets upset later.

She swipes open her phone and opens the Contacts app,
placing it face-up in front of Alex.

JASMINE (CONT'D)
And here's my phone. Unlocked.
You know... for...

ALEX
(slight smirk)
Oh. I wonder what that's for.

JASMINE
(sighing, smiling)
You know why.

ALEX
No, I don't.

JASMINE
Are you still going to keep your
number from me after all this?
Jasmine pouts in mock protest. Alex crosses her arms and
leans back.

ALEX
Hey, if you want my number that
badly, take me out to dinner
first.

JASMINE
Oh, I will. But number first,
please. And I can do better than
dinner – how about jazz? I happen
to own a jazz bar. Maybe I'll
serenade you. Good enough?

They both burst out laughing. In the middle of it, Alex
catches a glimpse of the Jasmine she knew – the short
waves framing her face, eyes shut, laughing wide. The
memory and the moment overlap, seamless.

Alex picks up the phone and saves her number. When she
exits the app, she notices Jasmine's lock screen: a photo
of the two of them in school, along with a few others.
Everyone is holding their instruments – Jasmine with her
guitar, a tall boy with dreads cradling a saxophone, and
Alex with a pipa.

JASMINE (CONT'D)
Nice wallpaper, right?

ALEX

Where did you even get this
photo?

JASMINE

Jacob passed it to me. Apparently
you both got one at the end of
the school year – but you know, I
was already in New York by then.

Alex studies the photo. Then she opens her desk drawer and
takes out a framed print of the same picture.

ALEX

How does it look in real life,
then?

JASMINE

(grinning)

You even framed it.

ALEX

Well, Jacob probably let his copy
collect dust in some drawer.

Jasmine takes the frame, holding it with the careful
tenderness of someone handling something they'd given up
on finding.

JASMINE

We should perform together again.

Alex lights up – then comes back to earth.

ALEX

It's been a while since I've
played music.

JASMINE

No, I mean – you could always
practise. Maybe in a few months,
once the club is steadier and you
have more breathing room, you can
perform with us!

Alex's hands fold on the desk. She's quiet for a moment.

ALEX

Actually... I might not be here
in a few months.

Jasmine's smile fades.

JASMINE

What do you mean?

ALEX

I got a job offer. In New York.
Magazine editor – it's a big one.
I haven't accepted yet, but...

JASMINE

That... that sounds great for
you. I'm... I'm happy for you.

Her eyes well up. She blinks it away and smiles.

JASMINE (CONT'D)

Wah, you were probably planning
to come apologise to me in New
York, huh? Hahaha – and now I'm
here and you're about to be
there. That's crazy...

The laugh doesn't quite reach her eyes.

JASMINE (CONT'D)

I am proud of you getting a good
job.

(MORE)

JASMINE (CONT'D)

I'm sure working here isn't
exactly great anyway. Ah, I
should leave – I've got to reopen
the bar tonight.

Jasmine stands, returning the photo frame to Alex's desk.

JASMINE (CONT'D)

Before you leave Singapore,
please come by the bar. I'll look
forward to it.

ALEX

Ah... yes. I'll be there. I
promise.

JASMINE

It was good talking to you, Alex.
And do keep in touch. You've got
fifteen years of catching up to
do.

Her voice catches slightly. Alex stands, wanting to close
the space between them.

JASMINE (CONT'D)

I'm proud of you, Alex. Take care
and... see you soon.

ALEX

Jas... thank you. See you soon.

Jasmine gives a small smile, then turns and walks out of
the office.

Alex watches her go. She sets the framed photo next to a
small cactus on her desk and looks at it for a long
moment, the setting sun warm through the glass behind her.
Nina appears at the door.

NINA

Hey – are you still up for that
meeting?

Alex glances at the photo one more time.

ALEX

Actually, reschedule it to
tomorrow. I'm heading out right
now.

NINA

Oh – do you have plans?

ALEX

I do. Now.

She packs her laptop and papers into her bag, then pauses
at the door.

ALEX (CONT'D)

You never actually scheduled that
meeting with my boss, did you?

Nina smiles and shakes her head. Alex lets out a small
sigh – and smiles too.

ALEX (CONT'D)

Bye Nina. See you tomorrow!

NINA

See you tomorrow, Alex!

Alex strides down the corridor. Nina leans against the glass door of the empty office, watching her go.

FADE OUT.

THE END